

Greece



The cradle of democracy, occupying the south of the Balkan peninsula and over 1,400 islands.

2300–1400 BCE Minoan culture flourishes on Crete and c.1400 BCE is superseded by mainland Mycenaeans.

490 BCE The Athenians defeat the Persian forces of King Darius at Marathon, marking the rise of the city-state of Athens and the golden age of Classical Greece.

356–323 BCE Philip of Macedon and his son Alexander the Great complete the conquest of the whole country. Alexander overthrows the Persian Empire and extends Greek rule as far as India. On his death his empire is divided into four.

146 CE The destruction of Corinth by Roman forces leads to the inclusion of the whole country in the Roman Empire.

395 CE As the Roman Empire is permanently divided, Greece falls into the Eastern (later Byzantine) half.

1387–1460 Ottomans conquer Greece.

1821 A Greek nationalist movement declares independence. Ottomans attempt to regain power, but the Greeks appeal for help from France, Britain, and Russia.

1828 Russia declares war on the Ottoman Empire in support of the Greeks: the Treaty of Adrianople of 1829 ending the war recognizes Greek autonomy.

1832 The London Conference establishes Greek independence and installs Otto, son of King Ludwig of Bavaria, as king.

1863 Greece gains the Ionian Islands and Cythera from the UK and Thessaly in 1881 from the Ottomans.



The Greek War of Independence

Inspired by the revolutions in America and France, the Greeks rose against their Turkish overlords in 1821, but suffered a disastrous defeat when the Turks besieged the port of Missolonghi in 1825 (above). The turning point in the war came with the destruction of a joint Ottoman–Egyptian fleet at Navarino Bay in 1827 by British, French, and Russian forces.

1908 Crete, autonomous in the Ottoman Empire, declares union with Greece.

1912 Italy seizes the Dodecanese Islands from the Ottoman Empire.

1912–13 In the two Balkan Wars, Greece gains Macedonia, southern Epirus, and eastern Aegean islands.

1913 George I is assassinated and is succeeded by Constantine I. His pro-German sympathies bring him into conflict with prime minister Eleftherios Venizelos, who takes Greece into World War I on the side of the Allies in 1917. Constantine abdicates in favor of his son Alexander, regains the throne on Alexander's death in 1920, but abdicates in 1922; he is succeeded by George II.

1919 Treaty of Neuilly awards Western Thrace to Greece, shutting Bulgaria off from the Adriatic.

1920–22 Greek attempts to gain Greek-speaking territory in Asia Minor after the collapse of the Ottoman Empire end in disaster; Greece recognizes Turkish rule over most of the disputed territory under 1923 Treaty of Lausanne. A mass migration of ethnic Turks into Turkey and ethnic Greeks into Greece ensues.

1924 A republic is declared and political instability leads to military intervention.

1935 A plebiscite following Venizelos's electoral defeat results in a vote to restore George II. After an inconclusive election in 1936, a right-wing dictatorship under General Ioannis Metaxas is established.

1941 Germany occupies Greece: rival royalist and communist-dominated National Liberation Front (EAM) resistance movements fight back. As the German army retreats in late 1944, the two groups fight for control of Greece.

1946 The monarchy is restored.

DECISIVE MOMENT

OUTBREAK OF THE GREEK CIVIL WAR, 1944

On December 3, 1944, a bitter civil war erupted in Athens between the communist (ELAS) and royalist (EDES) guerrilla groups that had jointly resisted the Germans during the wartime occupation. After the German withdrawal an uneasy coalition existed between the two that soon broke as ELAS guerrillas overran the whole of Greece except Athens and Salonika.

Although ELAS conceded defeat in 1945, the group went underground and resumed

full-scale guerrilla war in 1946. By the time the royalists eventually won in 1949, mainly due to massive US aid, more than 30,000 people had been killed in many acts of brutality and sabotage (below). For the Greeks the civil war left a deeper psychological scar than World War II. The left remained alienated and outside Greek politics until 1981, while many resistance fighters who had played an honorable part in the defeat of Germany lost their lives.



1946–49 Civil war: victory for royalists led by Marshall Aleksandros Papagos.

1947 Italy cedes Dodecanese to Greece.

1952 After a period of unstable governments, Papagos and his Greek Rally party win elections that also give women the vote for the first time.

1955 Papagos dies: the leadership of Greek Rally, now the National Radical Union, passes to Constantine Karamanlis.

1963–64 Opposition Center Union of George Papandreou wins power.

1967 Colonel George Papadopoulos seizes power in a coup; the king is exiled.

1973 Greece is declared a republic, with Papadopoulos as president.

1974 Greece leaves NATO in protest over the Turkish occupation of northern Cyprus. The "Colonels' regime" falls, having failed to help Cyprus; New Democracy (ND) wins elections with Constantine Karamanlis as premier.

1980 Karamanlis becomes president; Greece rejoins NATO.

1981 The Pan-Hellenic Socialist Movement (PASOK) wins elections with Andreas Papandreou as the first socialist premier.

1981 Greece joins the European Community (now EU).

1989 Two inconclusive elections lead to the formation of an all-party coalition.

1990 New Democracy wins elections but faces strikes against economic reforms.

1993 PASOK wins election: Andreas Papandreou returns as premier.

1996 Papandreou resigns as prime minister; succeeded by Kostas Simitis.

1999 Earthquakes in both Greece and Turkey gain a sympathetic response from both sides.

2002 Greece adopts the euro.

2004 Athens hosts the Olympic Games.

2004 ND, headed by Costas Karamanlis, defeats PASOK.

2007 Wildfires sweep through Greece, killing dozens. New Democracy narrowly wins reelection, despite criticism of its handling of the fires.

2009 Opposition PASOK wins snap election over the economy and George Papandreou becomes prime minister.

2010 Loss of confidence in Greek economy leads to funding crisis. Government debt reaches 120 percent of GDP. The EU establishes a fund to bail out Greece (and any other failing states' economies).

«76–77 Europe's First Civilization
«94–95 The Greek City-States
«98–99 The Greeks in Asia
«100–01 The Birth of Democracy
«104–05 Triumphs of Greek Science
«246–47 The Ottoman Empire